

Advertisement

AI



Sam Altman, over bread rolls, explores life after GPT-5



I'm looking out at Alcatraz Island from a Mediterranean restaurant in San Francisco with hundred-dollar fish entrées on the menu. As I make small talk with other reporters, OpenAI CEO Sam Altman jumps through the door on my left. Altman's looking down at his bare iPhone to show us all something, and an intrusive thought slips out of my mouth: "No phone case is a bold choice."

Of course, I immediately realize that the billionaire CEO of OpenAI, who employs Apple veteran Jony Ive, cares more about preserving the iPhone's original design than the \$1,000 it costs to replace one.

IMAGE CREDITS:

DAVID SHULMAN/REUTERS/CONTOUR BY GETTY IMAGES
"Listen, we're going to ship a device that is going to be so beautiful," says Altman, referring to [OpenAI and Ive's forthcoming AI device](#). "If you put a case over it, I will personally hunt you down," he jokes.

Altman has gathered roughly a dozen tech reporters to join him and other OpenAI executives for an on-the-record dinner (and off-the-record dessert). The night raises more questions than it answers.

For instance, why is Nick Turley, the VP of ChatGPT, kindly passing me a lamb skewer just a week after launching [GPT-5](#)? Is this to encourage me to write nice things about OpenAI's biggest AI model launch yet, which was relatively disappointing given the years of hype around it?

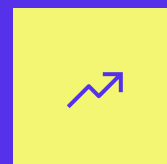
TEC DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- [HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent breach](#)
- [How your solar rooftop became a national security issue](#)
- [A comprehensive list of 2025 tech layoffs](#)
- [Co-founder of Elon Musk's xAI departs the company](#)
- [Google CEO adds a new calendar feature at Stripe co-founder's request](#)

Unlike GPT-4, which far outpaced rivals and challenged expectations of what AI can do, GPT-5 performs roughly on par with models from Google and Anthropic. OpenAI even brought [back GPT-4o](#) and [ChatGPT's model picker](#), after several users expressed concerns over GPT-5's tone and its model router.

But throughout the night, it becomes clear to me that this dinner is about OpenAI's future beyond GPT-5. OpenAI's executives give the impression that AI model launches are less important than they were when GPT-4 launched in 2023. After all, OpenAI is a very different company now, focused on upending legacy players in search, consumer hardware, and enterprise software.

- [NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars](#)
- [Why I finally left Spotify](#)



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

[REGISTER NOW](#)

OpenAI shares some new details about those efforts.

Altman says OpenAI's incoming CEO of applications, [Fidji Simo](#), will oversee multiple consumer apps outside of ChatGPT — ones OpenAI

has yet to launch. Simo is slated to start work at OpenAI in just a few weeks, and she might end up overseeing the launch of an [AI-powered browser](#) that OpenAI is reportedly developing to compete with Chrome.

Altman suggests OpenAI would even consider buying Chrome — likely an offer that would be taken more seriously than [Perplexity's bid](#) — should it become available. “If Chrome is really going to sell, we should take a look at it,” he says before looking at all of us and asking: “Is it actually going to sell? I assumed it wasn't gonna happen.”

Simo also might end up running an AI-powered [social media app](#) — something the OpenAI CEO has said he's interested in exploring. In fact, Altman says there's “nothing” inspiring to him about the way AI is used on social media today, adding that he's interested in “whether or not it is possible to build a much cooler kind of social experience with AI.”

While Turley and Brad Lightcap, OpenAI's COO, largely give the floor to Altman, drinking wine alongside the other seated guests, Altman also confirms reports that OpenAI plans to back a brain-computer interface startup, [Merge Labs](#), to compete with Elon Musk's Neuralink. (“We have not done that deal yet; I would like us to.”)

How intertwined that company will be with OpenAI's models and devices remains to be seen. Altman describes it only as a “a company that we'd invest in.”

For all the talk of browsers and brain chips, though, the elephant in the room remains GPT-5's rough reception. Eventually, the conversation circles back to the model that has prompted our group dinner in the first place.

Turley and Altman say they've learned a lot from the experience.

"I legitimately just thought we screwed that up," says Altman on deprecating GPT-4o without telling users. Altman says OpenAI will give users a more clear "transition period" when deprecating AI models in the future.

Turley also says OpenAI is already rolling out a new update to make GPT-5's responses "warmer," but not sycophantic, such that it won't reinforce negative behaviors in users.

"GPT-5 was just very to the point. I like that. I use the robot personality — I'm German, you know, whatever," says Turley. "But many people do not, and they really like the fact that ChatGPT would actually check in with you."

It's a delicate balance for OpenAI to strike, especially given that some users have developed dependencies on ChatGPT. Altman says OpenAI believes that less than 1% of ChatGPT users have unhealthy relationships with the chatbot — which could still be tens of millions of people.

Turley says OpenAI has worked with mental health experts to develop a rubric to evaluate GPT-5's answers, ensuring that the AI model will push back on unhealthy behaviors.

That said, it seems that GPT-5 hasn't hurt OpenAI's business. In fact, Altman says OpenAI's API traffic doubled within 48 hours of GPT-5's launch, and the company is effectively "out of GPUs" thanks to all the demand. Cursor and other AI coding assistants have since made GPT-5 their default AI models.

In many ways, the night's contradictions — disappointing launches, record-breaking usage — reflect OpenAI's strange reality right now.

Given OpenAI's bets — and others the company is making around data centers, robotics, and energy — Altman clearly has ambitions of running a much bigger company than just the ChatGPT maker. The final form could look something like Google's parent Alphabet, but perhaps even broader.

As the night winds down, it becomes clear we aren't gathered to reflect on GPT-5 at all. We are being pitched on a company that's eager to outgrow its famous and controversial product.

It seems likely that OpenAI will go public to meet its massive capital demands as part of that picture. In preparation, I think Altman wants to hone his relationship with the media. But he also wants OpenAI to get to a place where it's no longer defined by its best AI model.

Topics: [AI](#) [OpenAI](#) [sam altman](#)



Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter |

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg, and MSNBC,...

[View Bio](#) >

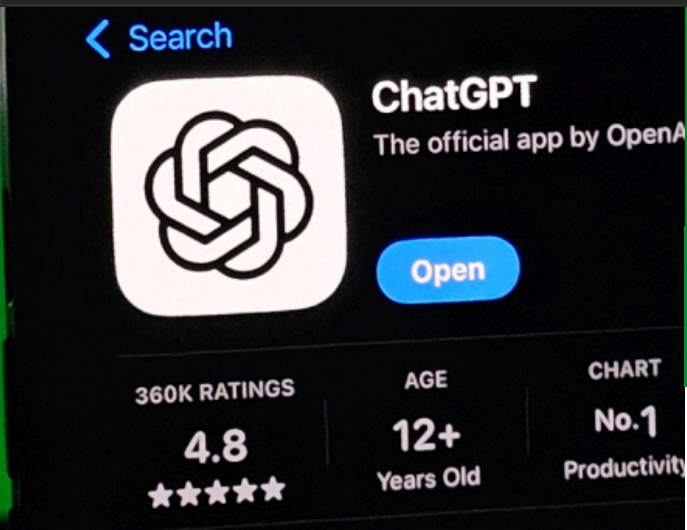
———— KEEP READING ————

Latest	Security
Startups	AI
Venture	Apps

Events

Podcasts

Newsletters



Ivan Mehta — 8:57 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

OpenAI today launched a new, cheaper ChatGPT paid subscription plan in India called ChatGPT GO, priced at ₹599 per month (\$4.60), which is more affordable than the ₹1,999 (about \$23) per month Plus Plan.

The company had turned on local currency pricing for all its plans a few days ago, and with this launch, it will also allow users to pay through UPI (Unified Payment Interface), India's payment framework.

Nick Turley, VP at OpenAI and head of ChatGPT, said that this plan will increase the message, image generation, and file uploads by 10 times over the free tier. The ChatGPT Go plan will also enable better memory retention for more personalized responses, Turley said.

We just launched ChatGPT Go in India, a new subscription tier that gives users in India more access to our most popular features: 10x higher

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

message limits, 10x more image generations, 10x more file uploads, and 2x longer memory compared with our free tier. All for Rs. 399. 🇮🇳

— Nick Turley (@nickaturley) [August 19, 2025](#)

“Making ChatGPT more affordable has been a key ask from users! We’re rolling out Go in India first and will learn from feedback before expanding to other countries,” Turley said.

From a currency conversion standpoint, the Plus plan was higher than \$20 for Indian users when offered in local currency. The new Go plan offers a more affordable alternative to people who are looking to use ChatGPT primarily for chat, image generation, and file processing.

Tibor Blaho, a software engineer with a reputation for accurately leaking upcoming AI products, had [previously teased](#) this plan and its details.

While the company is geo-restricting this plan to India, the company said on its [support page](#) that it is working to expand this plan to more regions.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).



Last month, Turley noted that ChatGPT now has more than [700 million weekly users](#) worldwide — up from 500 million in March. OpenAI launched its updated image generator feature for ChatGPT in March, [and since then, it has seen an uptick in usage in India](#). OpenAI CEO Sam Altman said in a recent podcast that India is [the company's second biggest market](#). With the Go plan, it wants to cash in on that.

According to app analytics firm AppFigures, India has been the leading country in terms of ChatGPT app downloads across platforms, with over 29 million downloads coming from the country in the last 90 days. However, the app only made \$3.6 million in this period from users in the country.

This move will likely nudge more consumers to subscribe to using ChatGPT more, given its pricing. Other AI companies have also made moves to attract users from the country's internet user base of over 850 million. Last month, Perplexity partnered with network provider Airtel to offer [free Perplexity Pro subscriptions](#). Google also dished up [a free AI Pro plan for India-based students for one year](#).

While OpenAI's move is not giving out any freebies, local and affordable pricing will likely result in a better subscription conversion rate for ChatGPT in India.

Topics: [AI](#) [Apps](#) [ChatGPT](#) [India](#) [OpenAI](#) [TC](#)





Ivan Mehta

✕ in

Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

View Bio >

KEEP READING



IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

STARTUPS



Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for

Latest in Startups

other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

[See More](#)

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh - 2 hours ago

STARTUPS



AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Julie Bort - 5 hours ago

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27

Isabelle Johannessen

- 23 hours ago

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company's "extremely aggressive product roadmap."



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

"The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product," Monaco said. "I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it."

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I’m seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That’s the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

We’re always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out [this survey](#) to let us know how we’re doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: [AI](#) [AI](#) [artificial intelligence](#) [Enterprise](#)

[enterprise startup](#) [Exclusive](#) [Fundraising](#)

[fundraising](#) [General Catalyst](#) [startup](#)

[startup fundraising](#) [Startups](#) [United States](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [🐼](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)

Rebecca Szkutak

Senior Reporter, Venture | [in](#)

Becca is a senior writer at TechCrunch that covers venture capital trends and startups. She previously covered the...

[View Bio](#) >

